

# Breaking barriers – tackling challenges in grassroots sports

**T**ackling challenges and breaking barriers at the grassroots were among the many issues on the agenda at the Sportstar Conclave — Focus Bihar. “Less than five per cent of the population has access to sports infrastructure. The whole programme about trying to provide very good sports facilities and split them out across the country is really the core. If we are looking to tap the population dividend that we have, we need to reach out to the other 95 per cent as well,” Anil Kumar, Managing Director of Great SportsTech, said.

“Schools being the hub of where most the kids are gathering, obviously, government schools should be entitled to an entirely government-funded sports infrastructure. Even for private schools, if you are able to subsidize 50 per cent of infrastructure cost, the school will also have skin in the game, and they will also invest,” he added during the panel discussion moderated by

Prasanth Shanthakumaran, Partner, KPMG India.

Rishikesh Joshi, Co-Founder and CEO of Sports For All, also highlighted the importance of leveraging India’s huge demographic dividend.

“80 lakh school children play organised sport in the US. India’s school population is 26 crore. If we did even five per cent of that at the school level, imagine how quickly we could catch up,” he said.

Meanwhile, CEO and Founder of Khelo More, Jatin Paranjape, shed light on making sports infrastructure more accessible to India’s urban population.

“The Indian gentry from the top 30 cities also needs to access some of the municipal corporation-owned sports complexes because that is when you will see the culture change. A lot more Indians will start playing sport. It is very important for Indians to think about sport in a freer way and to think about it as being something which needs to be included in their lives.”



The panelists agreed that sport should be an integral part of our lives in India and there is a lot of potential that can be tapped at the school level. R. V. MOORTHY